ONCE I WAS A TRAINED FAC, I had to become combat ready, which meant mastering twenty-eight different combat "controls."

A control was basically an interaction with an aircraft. Each control was a scenario, a little play. For instance, imagine two aircraft come into your airspace. *Good morning, this is Dude Zero One and Dude Zero Two. We're a pair of F-15s with two PGMs on board, plus one JDAM, we've got a playtime of ninety minutes and we are currently two nautical miles east of your location at Flight Level 150, waiting for talk-on…*

I needed to know precisely what they were saying, and how to respond to them precisely in their own jargon.

Sadly, I wouldn't be able to do this in a normal training area. The normal areas, like Salisbury Plain, were too out in the open. Someone would see me, and tip off the press, and my cover would be blown; I'd be back where I started. Instead, Colonel Ed and I decided that I should learn the controls somewhere remote…somewhere like…

Sandringham.

We both smiled when the thought occurred. Then laughed.

The last place anyone would think of Prince Harry getting himself combat ready. Granny's country estate.

I got a room at a small hotel near Sandringham—Knights Hill. I'd known the place all my life, driven past it a million times. Whenever we visited Granny at Christmas, our bodyguards would sleep there. Standard room: hundred quid.

In summers, Knights Hill tended to be full of bird-watchers, wedding parties. But now, in the autumn, it was empty.

The privacy was thrilling, and would've been total, if not for the older lady in the pub connected to the hotel. She watched me, goggle-eyed, every time I passed.

Alone, *almost* anonymous, my existence narrowed to one interesting task, I was delirious. I tried not to say so to Chelsy when I phoned her in the evenings, but it was the kind of happiness that's hard to hide.

I recall one difficult chat. What were we doing? Where were we heading?